JOHN ASARO

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New York, NY 10007 (open to relocation)

EDUCATION

CONNECTICUT COLLEGE, New London, CT — Expected graduation May 2026
Majors: Computer Science, Psychology
Honors/Awards: Dean's High Honors, Junior Computer Science Award, ECTA 2025 Best Poster Award

SELECTED WORK EXPERIENCE

AI Researcher, Autonomous Agent Learning Lab — July 2024 - Present
New London, CT

- Developed evolutionary learning systems for autonomous agents in simulated robotics and game environments, coauthoring two peer-reviewed papers accepted to ECTA 2025, one of which received the Best Poster award
- Collaborated with lab members to prototype and iterate on AI and robotics experiments, contributing Python based tooling and experimental code to support ongoing autonomous agent research

Computational Social Choice Researcher, Summer Science Research Institute (SSRI) — May 2024 - July 2024
New London, CT

- Conducted applied research on algorithmic decision making systems, focusing on how to aggregate individual preferences to maximize overall social benefit
- Designed and implemented a novel aggregation algorithm in Python and benchmarked it against widely used state-of-the-art methods across multiple quantitative metrics
- Demonstrated that the proposed algorithm consistently outperformed existing approaches in measured social benefit across both single-selection and multi-selection scenarios

Software Developer, Zummo Bike — August 2023 - December 2023
Remote

- Developed backend components for Zummo Manage, a data entry platform used by a nonprofit, improving the reliability and structure of inventory and client data management
- Built RESTful APIs with Flask to support CRUD workflows and power a Svelte-based frontend for real-time data entry and updates
- Integrated Stripe and Airtable APIs to enable payment processing and automated data synchronization, reducing manual operational overhead

PROJECTS

Viz Ikemen — July 2025 - October 2025

- Built Viz-Ikemen, a reinforcement learning platform for training vision-based AI agents in a real-time game environment
- Verified end-to-end environment correctness by training a Deep Q-Network (DQN) agent with sparse rewards, achieving a 100% win rate against a baseline opponent once observation and action interfaces were working perfectly
- Integrated the game engine with an external RL pipeline by adding real-time visual streaming and action control, enabling scalable, headless training across multiple parallel instances

PUBLICATIONS

Decentralized Evolution of Hexapod Gaits with Independent Leg Controllers
Gary B Parker, Jim O'Connor, John Asaro
IJCCI Conference on Evolutionary Computation and Theory and Applications (ECTA), 2025

Niching Agents in The Core
Gary B Parker, Jim O'Connor, John Asaro
IJCCI Conference on Evolutionary Computation and Theory and Applications (ECTA), 2025

SKILLS

Languages: Python, C++, C#, Java, Javascript, Go, Lua, and Scheme
Systems/Tools: Linux, Git, SQL, REST APIs, Azure, Flask, Svelte, PyTorch, Gymnasium, Matplotlib, NumPy